KEY MILESTONES IN THE BILL'S JOURNEY

In the past 27 years, multiple attempts have been made to provide reservation to women in Parliament



1996

First introduced in the Lok Sabha as the 81st Amendment Bill by the **H.D. Deve Gowda**-led United Front government in September. After failing to get the nod, it was referred to a joint parliamentary committee, which submitted its report to the Lok Sabha in December. The bill lapsed with the dissolution of the House.

Institute of Public Finance and Policy, the delay is insignificant given the historic nature of a decision that was long overdue. "Feminisation of governance is crucial to bring diversity, talent and insights to the table. More informed debates in Parliament on public policy innovations like gender budgeting require more women on board," she says.

The multiple criticisms notwithstanding, the introduction of this legislation on the eve of election season has added another chapter to the BJP's continued efforts to woo the female electorate via social welfare and empowerment schemes. It was only last month that the government reduced the price of domestic cooking gas cylinders. The Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana, introduced in 2016 to provide cooking gas to deprived households that earlier used firewood and coal as fuel, has been extended to an additional 7.5 million households.

Other schemes, such as Swachh Bharat, Jal Jeevan Mission, Sukanya Samriddhi, Beti Bachao Beti Padhao and Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana, are also being touted as providing dignity, ease of living, financial empowerment and inclusion, educational support and health benefits to women. The Prohibition of Child Marriage Amendment Bill, 2021, which proposes to increase the minimum age of marriage for women to 21 years, is being presented as another measure to empower women. A parliamentary standing committee is currently examining the bill. BJP leaders are also quick to point out that the Modi cabinet has 11 women ministers, the highest number in any Union government since Independence.

The saffron formation also hopes that the women's reservation bill will help it reverse the adverse publicity generated by the alleged mishandling of the protest by women wrestlers earlier this year, who had accused BJP MP Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, the then president of the Wrestling Federation of India, of sexual harassment. More importantly, the party wanted something dramatic to distract the voters from economic distress and the resentment over it. "The BJP was worried about economic issues such as price rise impacting their hold over women voters," says psephologist Yashwant Deshmukh. "This bill is likely to generate a healthy dose of goodwill for the BJP among women voters."

Political observers, though, warn that the delayed implementation may dilute the possible electoral gain for the BJP. "If the Opposition parties are able to effectively communicate to voters that women's reservation will not be implemented in the near future, then the BJP may not gain as much as it is hoping to," says Prof. Narender Kumar, chairperson, Centre for Political Studies, JNU. However, psephologist Pradeep Gupta, while agreeing on the reduced impact, places his bet on Modi's brand value. "The gap in legislation and implementation will reduce the electoral benefit for the BJP by 50 per cent, but what will work for the BJP is the Modi factor," he says. "Even if it is just a promise at the moment, the prime minister's track record of making things happen adds to the credibility of that promise."

Opposition parties hope that by fuelling concerns of the OBCs, they may split the BJP's Hindutva vote bank

WOMEN AS A VOTE BANK

The BJP's focus on women voters is hardly surprising. The female voter turnout has been steadily increasing since 1962, when 63.3 per cent men and just 46.6 per cent women had voted in the Lok Sabha election. In 2019, 67.2 per cent women voted in the polls, marginally surpassing the 67 per share of men. However, while more women voted for the Congress nationally till 2019, after that year, the BJP, for the first time ever, became the party with the highest share of female votes even though the party's vote share among men (39 per cent) continues to be marginally higher than among women (36 per cent), according to a study by the Delhi-based Centre for the Study of Developing Societies. The BJP government's law criminalising triple talaq is said to have earned the party significant support even among Muslim women in the 2019 general election.